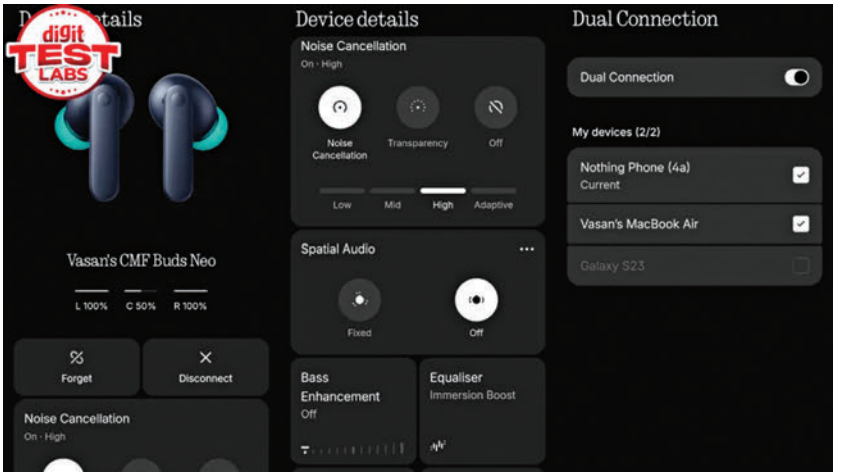
either off or at a lower volume. In an office environment, this is also pretty useful if you like listening to some focus music but still want to be aware of someone talking to you.

As for calls, the Buds Neo use four microphones, two on each earbud, along with CMF's Clear Voice Technology. Indoor call quality was fine for both parties. When the background noise is loud and close to you, the other person can hear it. But the experience was clear enough for calls and meetings.




## NOTHING X APP IS MINIMAL AND FUNCTIONAL

Changing many of these settings, like ANC level, Spatial Audio, Bass Enhancement level, Equalizer mode, and Tap controls, happens through the Nothing X app. You can also enable Dual Connection, Adaptive ANC mode, Low Lag mode, find misplaced earbuds, update the Buds Neo's firmware, and see the current battery life of the earbuds on the app's home screen.

The Nothing X app shares a minimal yet very functional UI. Besides the EQ presets, the app also lets you fine-tune equaliser profiles. So there are granular customisation options, which is good to get in this price range.

That said, Nothing has omitted a key feature like wear detection. So, you have to manually pause the music by tapping. And for manual pairing as well, you need to touch and hold both earbuds for a few seconds. So, there are some minor inconveniences which you may or may not find annoying. By the way, the initial pairing was smooth, and the connectivity was stable thanks to the Buds Neo supporting Bluetooth 6.0, Google Fast Pair, and Microsoft Swift Pair.




## BATTERY LIFE IS ONE OF THE STRONGEST ASPECTS

Battery life is solid. In our continuous music run test with the earbuds playing a FLAC file at 80% volume and ANC on, the CMF buds ended up at 1% charge after running for 8 hours. With ANC off, the claimed runtime is 11 hours from the buds and up to 52 hours with the case. So, these can easily last a workday, and the case can manage the longevity for a weekend trip.

Nothing says the earbuds can gain up to 5.5 hours of playback from zero with a 10-minute fast charge. The case has a USB-C port. The company has definitely cut some costs by not including a charging cable in the box.

## SHOULD YOU BUY THE CMF BUDS NEO?

For a budget pair costing Rs 2,100, the CMF Buds Neo cover most of the basics, including respectable active noise cancellation. I was glad I carried these with me on my Kerala train journey. The comfortable fit, responsive tap-based controls, an energetic and enjoyable audio, good battery life, a functional Nothing X app with useful features like dual-device connectivity, low-lag mode, and a fine share of customisability to the soundscape often came in handy.

Nothing has cut some corners by not including a USB cable in the box and by not including wear detection in the buds. The treble lacks some detail and sparkle; complex tracks can sound a little congested. But the bass emphasis isn't to the detriment of vocals and most instruments. The audio is still, like I said, enjoyable.

Now the bigger question is whether it makes sense to spend a little more. Well, you can expect better audio tuning, stronger ANC, and a lower-latency mode in a largely similar design. If you can stretch the budget, Nothing also has the CMF Buds 2a and Buds 2 within the Rs 3,000 ceiling. But if you want the best value, the Buds Neo make sense. It can be a good enough purchase as your primary pair of TWS earbuds or as an affordable secondary pair for work, travel, or commuting.

– G S Vasan

### SPECIFICATIONS

Audio drivers: 12.4 mm Dynamic Drivers | ANC: Upto 35dB Adaptive | Playback: 52 Hours | Microphones: 4 HD Clarity Mics | IP rating: IP54 | Connectivity: Bluetooth 6.0, Google Fast Pair, Microsoft Swift Pair | Charging: USB Type-C

### CONTACT

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